

The Primordial Cause of Disease

Prajñāparādha - Why Knowing What Is Right Is Often Not Enough

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धीधृतिस्मृतिविभ्रष्टः कर्म यत् कुरुतेऽशुभम् । प्रज्ञापराधं तं विद्यात् सर्वदोषप्रकोपणम् ॥

--- चरकसंहिता शरीरस्थान (9.902)

When proper understanding (dhī), restraint (dhr̥ti), and memory (smṛti) become impaired, a person performs unwholesome actions. This is called prajñāparādha - the failure of the intellect - and it aggravates all the doṣas. - Caraka Saṃhitā, Śārīrasthāna (1.102)

Most discussions about health begin with the body. We are told what to eat, how much to exercise, how long to sleep, and how to manage stress. These questions are undeniably important. Yet Ayurveda begins somewhere entirely different. Before asking what we should do, let us begin with some fundamental questions:

“Who do we think we are? If we wish to be healthy to ‘enjoy’ what life has to offer, why do we do such things that impair this very foundation of health?”

According to Ayurveda, the deepest cause of disease is not simply an unhealthy diet, poor habits, or an irregular lifestyle. These are only the visible expressions of a deeper disturbance. At the root lies *prajñāparādha*, literally “the failure of wisdom” or “the offence against one’s own higher intelligence”. In other words, it is misidentification - a gradual forgetting of our true nature and a mistaken identification with roles, labels, and external definitions.

“I Am This”: How Identity Is Quietly Constructed

From early childhood, we learn to define ourselves through labels: “student”, “engineer”, “researcher”, “athlete”, “successful”, “unsuccessful”, “introvert”, and “extrovert”. These labels are useful for describing what we do or how we appear. Over time, however, they quietly become our identity. We begin to think, “This is simply who I am.” We say, “I am sick” or “I have this disease”, until the distinction between ourselves and our circumstances gradually disappears.

Ayurveda observes that this subtle shift from experience to identity has profound consequences. When our identity becomes inseparable from external roles and achievements, our sense of stability depends upon circumstances that are constantly changing. Success inflates us. Failure diminishes us. Praise strengthens us. Criticism unsettles us. We begin to live from a place of constant comparison and pressure. The inner sense of stability is replaced by a fragile self-image that must be continuously defended, proven, or improved. This is not merely a philosophical problem. It is a physiological one. The mind remains in a state of constant reaction to the external world, and the nervous system stays alert. Rest becomes difficult. Digestion weakens. Sleep becomes shallow. Over time, this constant inner tension expresses itself as disease. Ayurveda describes this state as a form of illusion - not in the dramatic sense, but as a quiet confusion between who we are and what we do. When perception is distorted in this way, imbalance becomes inevitable.

Ego and the Fragmented Self

In Ayurveda, *ahaṅkāra*, often translated as the ego, is not viewed simply as arrogance or pride. It is the faculty through which we construct a sense of individuality and identity. By itself, it is neither good nor bad. It becomes problematic only when it mistakes temporary roles for the whole of who we are. When every decision is filtered through questions such as “How will this make me look?”, “Will this increase my status?”, or “What will others think

of me?”, clarity gradually gives way to attachment, fear, and desire. The intellect begins serving the ego rather than guiding it.

Life may continue to appear successful from the outside, yet inwardly it becomes increasingly fragmented. Thoughts, values, and actions no longer move in the same direction. This inner disharmony lays the foundation upon which disease eventually develops.

Prajñāparādha: The Root of All Disease

Ayurveda repeatedly identifies *prajñāparādha* as one of the fundamental causes of disease. It is not simply making a poor decision. It is the gradual weakening of three essential faculties: *dhī* - the capacity to discern what is right and beneficial; *dhṛti* - the strength to act according to that understanding; and *smṛti* - the ability to remember what one has learned through experience and wisdom. When these faculties function harmoniously, knowledge naturally guides action. But when they become impaired, even an intelligent and educated person repeatedly chooses what is harmful.

This is why Ayurveda does not equate knowledge with wisdom. One may know that inadequate sleep is harmful, yet continue sacrificing it for work. One may understand that certain foods cause discomfort, yet continue consuming them. One may recognize the importance of moderation, yet repeatedly choose excess. The problem is not ignorance. The problem is that knowledge has ceased to govern action.

Knowing What Is Right - Yet Doing What Is Wrong

This insight explains one of the great paradoxes of human behaviour. Most people already possess enough information to improve their health. They know when they should rest. They know when they are overeating. They know when stress is becoming excessive. They know that many of their daily habits are unsustainable.

Yet they continue. Ayurveda does not interpret this as a failure of intelligence or willpower. Rather, it sees it as the consequence of *prajñāparādha*. When discernment, restraint, and right remembrance weaken, decisions are increasingly driven by attachment, habit, social expectation, and immediate gratification rather than by genuine wisdom. Disease, therefore, is often not the result of a single catastrophic event. It is the cumulative consequence of countless small choices made when wisdom was present but not followed.

Healing by Study of Oneself - From Fragmentation to Wholeness

If the root of disease lies in distorted perception, then healing must begin by restoring clarity. For this reason, Ayurveda places great importance on being *samīkṣyakārī* (Aṣṭāṅgahṛdayam, Sūtrasthāna 4.36): honestly observing one's own patterns of thought, speech, and behaviour. Why do I repeatedly make the same choices? What truly motivates my actions? Which desires genuinely support well-being, and which merely promise temporary satisfaction? Such observation gradually strengthens *dhī*, *dhṛti*, and *smṛti*. The gap between knowing and doing begins to narrow. Wisdom ceases to be merely intellectual and becomes something that informs everyday life.

Viewed in this light, Ayurveda is much more than a system of medicine. It is a comprehensive framework for understanding the human being. Disease is not merely an imbalance of bodily tissues or physiological processes. At its deepest level, it reflects a loss of inner coherence, where perception, thought, and action no longer move together. Healing, therefore, is not simply the removal of symptoms. It is the gradual restoration of harmony between understanding, intention, and action. Medicines, therapies, diet, and lifestyle all have an indispensable role in restoring health. Yet Ayurveda reminds us that lasting well-being ultimately depends upon the restoration of *prajñā*, the wisdom that enables us to live in accordance with our own nature. When we remember that we are more than our roles, more than our achievements, and more than the identities we accumulate throughout life, our choices begin to change. As our choices change, our way of living changes. And as our way of living changes, health naturally follows. Before the next lecture, pause for a moment and ask yourself: “*Is there an area of my life where I already know what is beneficial, yet repeatedly choose otherwise?*” Observe your answer without judgement. According to Ayurveda, that honest observation may itself be the first step towards healing.